The Hundred and Eight Names of Noble Avalokiteśvara

Āryāvalokiteśvarasya Nāmāṣṭaśataka · Toh 900 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་སྤྱན་ར་ས་གཟིགས་དབང་ཕྱུག་གི་མཚན་བར་བརྒྱད་རྩ་བརྒྱད་པ།

The Hundred and Eight Names of Noble Avalokiteśvara, known in Sanskrit as the Āryāvalokiteśvarasya Nāmāṣṭaśataka and in Tibetan as the Phakpa Chenrezik Wangchuk gi Tsen Gya Tsa Gyepa, is a short scripture praising the bodhisattva of compassion through a litany of one hundred and eight names and epithets. It opens in the manner of a sutra, with the Blessed One dwelling at Avalokiteśvara's own abode on the summit of the palace of Mount Potala. That jewel-adorned and fragrant setting is filled with a vast assembly of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and other beings who gather to honor him and hear his teaching. Texts of this kind belong to the genre of name litanies, whose recitation is held to bring blessings, protection, and merit, and they are closely tied to the practice of dhāraṇī and devotional recitation. The work is Toh 900 in the Kangyur, where it is placed among the tantric and dhāraṇī texts devoted to recitation and invocation.

In the language of India: āryāvalokiteśvarasya nāmāṣṭaśatakaṃ
In the language of Tibet: The Hundred and Eight Names of Noble Avalokiteśvara.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at the abode of noble Avalokiteśvara, on the summit of the palace of Mount Potala, in a place adorned with many kinds of fragrant flowers, the color of Jambūnada gold, and blazing all around with many kinds of jewels. Many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans and nonhumans showed reverence to the Blessed One, held him as their master, served him, made offerings to him and honored him. They surrounded him on all sides and sat before him, and he taught them the Dharma. He fully and perfectly taught a pure way of life that was good in the beginning, good in the middle and good in the end, excellent in meaning and excellent in wording, unmixed, completely clean, completely pure, completely perfect and completely clear.

Then Brahmā and the others praised the bodhisattva, the great being, noble Avalokiteśvara:

"O, O Buddha, Blessed One,
You have done what was to be done and are skilled in action.
You have laid down the burden and attained your own aim.
The ties that bind to existence are wholly exhausted.
Through perfect understanding your mind is liberated,
And your wisdom is utterly liberated.
A great nāga, a thoroughbred,
You have reached the supreme perfection
Of every mastery over the mind.
Your accumulation of wisdom is complete.
You have crossed the wilderness of existence.
You strive to bring benefit to others.
Your heart is bound up with compassion.
You love all creatures supremely.
Your striving for their happiness springs from love.
You are skilled in liberating limitless beings.
You are born from the Sugata himself,
You are the very word of the Sugata,
The one friend of all the three realms.
You are free of attachment, aversion and delusion.
You have wholly abandoned the three stains.
You have gone beyond to the far shore of the three knowledges,
And you have attained the six superknowledges as well.
You are rounded like a nyagrodha tree.
You possess the thirty-two
Major marks of a great being,
And your body is adorned in every way
By the eighty excellent minor marks as well.
The hue of your body is like the color of gold.
Your stature is great, and you are fair,
Your color slightly reddish,
Like a young nāgakesara flower.
You have a topknot on your head,
And you are covered with many locks of hair.
Amitābha sits upon your head.
Rays of light stream out from you.
A halo a fathom wide blazes brilliantly.
Like a golden mountain, you are pervaded by fame.

Your splendor is exceedingly great.
You wear a crest like the sun
Rising over the eastern mountain.
With a sash of blazing precious jewels
Half your body is adorned.
You are highly skilled in the grounds.
You practice the ten perfections.
Your moral discipline knows no decline or breach.
Your hair is dark blue, like a lion's mane.
Your body is soft and graceful.
Your gaze and your gait are like a bull's,
And you are like a conch that spirals to the right.
Your forehead is like the half moon,
And the shape of your forehead is broad.
Your brows meet without a gap.
Your eyes blaze like precious jewels.
The shape of your nose is slightly raised.
The row of your teeth outshines all.
Your tongue can cover the great trichiliocosm,
And your ear openings are very deep.
Your neck is like the neck of a vase.
Your shoulders are well rounded.
The joints of your fingers are long.
Your fingers are soft and slightly red,
And between your fingers they are joined.
The palms of your hands and the soles of your feet
Are beautifully adorned with wheels.
You are lovely as an autumn lotus.
Your complexion is smooth, your nose full.
Your voice is sweet like Brahmā's voice,
Pleasing to the mind and bringing joy.
You are lovely to behold, your radiance delightful.
Born from a lotus, you are like a lotus.
You are arisen wholly from lotuses.
You are seated on a lotus seat.
You hold an excellent lotus in your hand.
You hold a water flask in your hand.

Wearing the skin of a black antelope,
You carry a staff and a rosary.
You are made pure by auspiciousness.
You speak first, and you speak with sincerity.
You let fall a rain of nectar.
Like a precious wish-fulfilling jewel,
You bring joy to all sentient beings.
Like a tree of beautiful appearance,
You become the nourishment of all beings.
You are an emanation of the Buddha.
You bear the guise of a sugata.
You hold the relics of the Sugata.
Even each single hair of your body
Has become a lord of sentient beings.
You make merit and you do what is virtuous.
Without delay you act decisively.
You possess the fiercest diligence.
You have crossed beyond saṃsāra.
You are enthroned as regent of the true Dharma.
As Cintāmaṇicakra you join beings to virtue.
As Amoghapāśa you draw them out of suffering.
As Hayagrīva you crush the four māras.
As Krodha Nīlakaṇṭha you dispel the vicious.
As the one on the makara throne you free them from fear.
The goddess Tārā follows after you.
Bhṛkuṭī carries out your commands.
The Victorious One is endowed with propriety.
You possess great power and possess mindfulness.
You possess good qualities and possess love.
You possess wisdom and possess glory.
You possess moral discipline and possess meaning.
You are the knower of all things,
The one who cuts through all doubts,
The one who speaks all dharmas,
The teacher of the worlds.
Your fair face is like the full moon.
Your lower body is adorned with every jewel.

You stand like a golden stūpa.
Your light rays surpass a thousand suns.
Brahmā and the others pay you homage."

Whoever praises noble Avalokiteśvara with these hundred and eight names will be fully purified of the karmic obscurations of having committed the five acts of immediate retribution. Such a person will enter all maṇḍalas. All secret mantras will be accomplished as well. For a thousand eons such a person will not be born in the lower realms, and will not go to Avīci hell.

Whoever rises in the morning and reads it, has it read, or recites it from memory, that person's body will be freed from all illnesses such as leprosy, boils, lung disease and difficulty in breathing. In every birth that person will remember former births. They will become like a son of the gods. At the time of death, too, they will be born in the world realm of Sukhāvatī. Wherever they are born and wherever they dwell, they will never be parted from noble Avalokiteśvara. If one constantly recites it, one's mind will become clear and sharp. One will become courageous. One's voice will become sweet. One will become fortunate. One will become learned in all the treatises.

One's speech will become dignified. If one praises him with this praise, it will be as though one had made offerings to buddhas, blessed ones, as many as the grains of sand in sixty-two Ganges rivers. Since the karmic maturation is also the same as that, there is no difference.

This concludes The One Hundred and Eight Names of Noble Avalokiteśvara, called The Jewel Casket of the Relics of All the Victors.

Translator's Notes

• The verse line on the antelope skin reads "man bas," which makes no sense here. It has been taken as a slip for a verb meaning "wearing" (mnabs or gyon pas). The phrase "se ral kha" is rendered "sash," which is uncertain. "The one on the makara throne" renders "chu srin 'dzin khri," which is not a form of Avalokiteśvara I can identify with confidence. The line could also be read as freeing beings from the terror of being seized by sea monsters. Likewise "the Victorious One" renders "rgyal ba can," which may be a goddess of the retinue such as Jayā, but this identification is not secure.
• In the title, the word that the glossary gives as "major mark" means "name" here, as in "the one hundred and eight names." The phrase rendered "speech will become dignified" could also be understood as speech that is noble, venerable or trustworthy.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.